

[Return to Search](#)

The language of secrecy

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[We used to think of it as a joke]
 Long lii he jinaa koi
 Child heart not men stomach
 [Men do not have feelings for a child]
 jina kele hiyima wo ka
 Men every agreement [or join] talk [this] is
 [This is an agreement reached by all men]
 Nyanbe meni pawlaw kula joe kaie
 I have matter original take-out [unfolds] Zo in my hand
 [I have a Zo that can reveal original matters]
 Bele aa pene aa wanlanwanlan
 The play [performance or ritual] has changed to seriousness
 [The play has become serious]
 Wele kelen ngon tol原因 wala
 Song hot [as a state of being] to sing strong
 [It is hard to sing a hot song]
 Jinaa dali aa nloi namu long
 Men are gone with landowner child
 [The men have gone away with the landowner's child]
 Long lElE ponon kayea
 Child good substitute in my hand
 [I have a good child to substitute]
 Nu ngai lawwa malan ngan
 Person face is just friend face
 [A person's face is just his friend's face]

539
[Literary Texts](#)

The song demonstrates knowledge that the initiates are not, as the ritual metaphors assert, dead. It instead recognizes that the boys are in the men's

539
[Literary Texts](#)

custody and expresses the mothers' concern about the general callousness of men toward children ("men do not have feelings for a child"). The boys' departure from the community is attributed to "an agreement reached by all the men" as revealed by the "Zo that can reveal original matters." Before the initiations, there is a great deal of joking and teasing of the initiates about their having to do battle with the devil (an example is presented in the next chapter). What is initially a joke is, in the song, recognized as serious ("the play has become serious"). The town chief, as the owner of the land, is given respect in the lines about substituting the singers' children for his own. The ability to substitute one boy for another derives from the prior practice of substituting poorer or  88 lower status townsmen during time of war. The fact that "a person's face is just his friend's face" asserts how one is as good as another.

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